the signing of the Geneva Accord and Indian and Soviet support, Najibullah's position became so tenuous that many in India, including Dixit, began to wonder whether he had become a liability.

India kept reiterating the strict implementation of the accord to little effect.[140] Rajiv himself was desperate to keep the situation under control. His 'bizarre' (and failed) invitation to Zia in February 1988 via the then foreign secretary K. P. S. Menon, two months before the accord to discuss the situation in Afghanistan, was one of the many signs that Rajiv was clutching at straws.[141] In May 1988 he dispatched Principal Secretary Gopi Arora to invite Najibullah to India.[142] It was a daring act in light of Najibullah's political fragility and the growing criticism of Rajiv's 'closeness' with Kabul, especially in the context of the IC-452 incident, and only served to widen India and Pakistan's rift over Afghanistan.[143] There were many indicators, as the Indian media reported, that the Najibullah government may be swept away in the coming months, or Najibullah's 'rivals in the PDPA may replace him with someone more acceptable to the leaders of at least some Mujahideen groups, or, indeed that even the Soviets may drop him as being inconvenient'.[144] Even India's ambassador to Kabul, I. P. Khosla, who had taken over the mantle from Dixit in 1985 (and remained there till 1989), thought that Rajiv was not being strategic. Making his reservations clear to the MEA, Khosla asked:

> Why we were [sic] inviting Najib, when his government was clearly not going to last. I suggested [to the MEA] that in the long run it might be better to cultivate relations with the other groups instead of boosting him [Najibullah]. But it was probably too late to get into strategic mode after half a century of something else.[145]

By early 1989, most Western countries, fearing violence in Kabul, had reduced their embassy staff in Kabul, and were recommending the same to New Delhi. Khosla, who had been pressing New Delhi to reconsider its policy towards Najibullah, had also sent his family back to New Delhi from Kabul.[146] In this context, in February 1989, Rajiv ordered the then chief of R&AW, Anand Kumar Verma, to secretly visit Kabul and form an assessment of Najibullah's political longevity. Accompanied by fellow intelligence officer Vappala Balachandran, Verma met with a host of contacts in Afghanistan during his two-three day visit and returned upbeat. He pressed Rajiv to continue aligning with Najibullah. In